allowance to be reduced even after it has been demonstrated down the same canal system that productivity does not get adversely affected even when water allowance is reduced to less wasteful levels. This surfeit of water created lakes of brackish water in the desert as the gypsum layers did not allow the water to seep down.

Large irrigation projects are still being undertaken in several states. The Accelerated Irrigation Benefit Programme (AIBP) later brought under the umbrella scheme of 'Har Khet Ko Paani' has been going on for decades to provide central funds and loans to states to complete 100-odd major irrigation projects.

The focus on providing drinking water to India's 30 crore households has been less sharp, until recently when the scheme to provide piped water to every family was launched under the Jal Jeevan Mission.

Again, India's lopsided water policies have done great disservice to the nation's economy. Hearteningly, there is now some recognition of this and a move to correct the unproductive waste of the country's limited land and water resources.

India Has Wasted the Economic Potential of Women

The modelled estimates of the International Labour Organization (ILO) put India's female labour participation rate at a measly 20.3 per cent in 2020. The global female work participation rate is 46.9 per cent. India's female labour participation rate is one of the lowest in the world. More worryingly, the rate is falling continuously after 2005, when it was 31.8 per cent. It fell precipitously to 22.9 per cent in 2012. Thereafter, too, it has fallen every year, though more gradually.

When only one in five of India's potential female labour force works to produce economic goods and services for the market, a large potential of generating economic value and growth gets lost. Why have we let the situation come to such a pass and why has the policy framework not done